Bikes in Schools 101

Bikes in Schools is a complete biking package built right into a school, so every child gets to ride during the school day, not just the kids who already have a bike at home.







What's in the package

Bikes	A fleet of 30 to 50 quality bikes, usually across four sizes
Helmets	A good-quality helmet for every child
Tracks	A riding track, pump track, skills track, or some combination
Storage	Secure bike storage, usually a converted shipping container
Training	Introductory cycle skills training, free through BikeReady

The school owns everything: the bikes, the helmets, the tracks and the storage. It all stays on school grounds, ready to use every day.

Why it matters

28 → 4
minutes a week New Zealand 5 to 12 year olds spent biking, 1990 to 2014

30% → 100%
of students with regular access to a bike once a project opens

Since 2010, more than 400 schools have set up Bikes in Schools or a similar project, and over 200,000 children now ride at school.

What it costs

Approximate figures for an average school of 300 students, excluding GST.

50 bikes	$15,000
100 helmets	$3,000
Riding track (limestone), 300m	$45,000
Pump track	$15,000
Skills track	$7,000
Bike storage (converted container)	$15,000
Average total	**$100,000**

A similar project with asphalt tracks runs closer to $125,000. Budget around $3,000 a year for maintenance. Costs vary by region, and track building is the biggest variable.

Who funds it

Schools usually combine several sources: community groups, foundations and trusts; local councils; businesses, particularly local contractors; government agencies; and parents and the wider school community. Some schools have also used their Ministry of Education property budget for tracks.

What people say

> "We think it is a great idea. It's a great way of introducing kids to bikes and making sure every young New Zealander gets an opportunity to learn to ride a bike … and it's certainly going to help us get fitter, healthier, more engaged young people."
>
> **Hon John Key**, Former Prime Minister of New Zealand

> "When I started riding at school it ended up crossing over towards my school work. Because I was getting better at BMX, I started getting better at school because it just gave me a lot of confidence, so I was happier and got better at everything really."
>
> **Sarah Walker**, World Champion BMX Rider and Olympic Medallist

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The three tracks



Riding track

Where most of the riding happens. It usually runs around the outside of the playing fields, and fifty or more kids can ride at once. Schools also use it for walking, running and triathlons.



Pump track

Kids pump their bikes through the rollers rather than pedalling. It is the track kids love most. Around 20m by 20m, mostly dirt with limestone on top, six riders at a time.



Skills track

A limestone track with obstacles such as skinnies, a slalom and a see-saw. It asks for concentration rather than speed. Around 10m by 30m, six riders at a time.

How to plan your project

1. **Get your school behind it** ☐
   Talk to your principal, teachers, Board of Trustees and parents, and decide who will lead the project. Visit a nearby school that already has tracks.
2. **Work out what you need and get quotes** ☐
   Work out how many bikes and helmets suit your roll, which tracks fit your grounds, and whether you need storage. Get quotes, including from local bike shops.
3. **Get Board approval and line up funding** ☐
   Confirm Board approval before fundraising. Most funders want a letter of Board support and a minuted resolution covering where, who and how much. Funding usually comes from several sources rather than one grant.
4. **Build the tracks** ☐
   Where you can, wait until all or most of the funding is confirmed, so contractors can be on-site together and share equipment.
5. **Order bikes, helmets and storage** ☐
   If you are getting a shipping container, check the delivery truck can reach the spot where it will sit.
6. **Book cycle skills training** ☐
   Contact your local provider (usually your council, a Regional Sports Trust or local Police) in advance, so training runs from the day the tracks open.
7. **Hold your opening and keep it going** ☐
   Most schools hold an official opening with a local Mayor, MP or sportsperson, and use it to thank their funders. Set aside around $3,000 a year for maintenance.

Free advice for any school

We offer free, hands-on advice to any school or council in New Zealand. The full guide, a map of schools near you, and teaching resources are on our website.

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